

Building Queries: An Exploration

```
$ echo "Data Sciences Institute"
```

Building Queries:

→ **Fundamental Three Commands**

Two More Commands

Putting Things Together with JOIN

Fundamental Three Commands

Fundamental Three Commands

- Our first three commands (`SELECT` , `FROM` , `WHERE`) are essential to nearly every SQL query
- The template for our initial SQL statement is as such:

`SELECT` : *the columns we want to retrieve*

`FROM` : *the table we are querying*

`WHERE` : *filters/conditions (optional)*

`ORDER BY` : *column sorting: ascending `ASC` or descending `DESC` (optional)*

`LIMIT` : *how many rows we want to return (optional)*

Fundamental Three Commands

- Always specified in this order:
 - `SELECT` will come first
 - `FROM` will come after `SELECT`
 - when we are querying more than one table at a time, each will come after `FROM` but before `WHERE` (more on this later)
 - `WHERE` will come after `FROM`
 - `ORDER BY` will come after `WHERE` clauses

Fundamental Three Commands

- We'll sometimes use the `LIMIT` clause to look at data
 - This comes at the very end of a query
 - `LIMIT` shouldn't be used for analytics unless you have a specific reason
 - `ORDER BY` often impacts the usefulness of `LIMIT`
- Remember:
 - In SQL, we use two dashes `--` to comment out lines, rather than `#`

SELECT Command

- At its simplest `SELECT` specifies column names we are retrieving
 - commas come between each column name
 - `SELECT student, course, grade ...`
 - column names with a space need to be enclosed in square brackets
 - `SELECT [poorly named column], better_column_name, AnotherColumnName`

SELECT Command

- Within `SELECT` statements we can perform manipulations on columns
 - e.g. rename a column
 - `SELECT [poorly named column] AS better_col`
 - combine two text columns
 - perform math on a numeric column
 - ...and many more things

SELECT Command

- We can use `SELECT` to perform math without a `FROM` statement
 - `SELECT 1 + 1`
 - `SELECT 10*5, cos(2), pi()`
- And we can use `SELECT` to specify constant values
 - `SELECT 2026 AS this_year, 'March' AS this_month`
- When selecting columns, they need to exist in the table!

FROM Command

- `FROM` statements indicate which table the data is from and where the table is located
 - in more complicated RDBMs, you will often have multiple databases on the same server and multiple schema within those databases
 - a fully qualified location of a table would thus be `database.schema.table`
- `SELECT * FROM table_name` indicates *everything* in the table
- Best practice suggests that we should explicitly call each column, even if we want all of them
 - **Why do we think this is the case?**   **Think, Pair, Share**

SELECT & FROM

(SELECT & FROM live coding)

WHERE Command

- `WHERE` clauses are conditions that the query will follow
- When we want to have multiple conditions, we use a single `WHERE` and then additional logical operations
- `WHERE` clauses always return rows evaluating to `TRUE`
 - Follows Boolean rules if more than one condition is present

WHERE Command

```
SELECT *  
FROM students  
WHERE first_name = 'Thomas'  
AND last_name = 'Rosenthal'
```

- **Notice we put string values in single quotes**
 - SQLite also allows double quotes, with a few minor caveats

WHERE Command

Logical Operators

- AND
- OR
- NOT
- NOT IN
- equals: =
- does not equal: <> !=
 - (flavour dependent)

WHERE Command

Logical Operators (continued...)

- greater than (equal to): `>` `>=`
- less than (equal to): `<` `<=`
- `BETWEEN`
- `EXISTS`
 - table specific
- `IS`
 - `NULL` specific

WHERE Command

- `NULL` is not a value (it's the absence of a value)
 - to check null values, we use `IS NULL` or `IS NOT NULL`
 - `= NULL` will not work

WHERE Command

- `LIKE` allows for string wildcards
- `%` specifies the wildcard placement
 - `country_name LIKE 'and%'`
 - Andorra
 - `country_name LIKE '%and'`
 - Finland, Iceland ...more
 - `country_name LIKE '%and%'`
 - all of the above, *plus* Antigua and Barbuda, Netherlands, Rwanda ...more!
 - `country_name LIKE '%an%d%'`
 - Canada ...surely more!

WHERE Command

(WHERE live coding)

What questions do you have about **SELECT**, **FROM**,
WHERE ?

Building Queries:

Fundamental Three Commands

→ Two More Commands

Putting Things Together with JOIN

Two More Commands

- **CASE** : Implements conditional logic.
- **DISTINCT** : Returns unique values.

CASE Command

- `CASE` statements allow us to introduce conditional logic into our `SELECT` statements

CASE Command

- They are generally similar to `if` or `if else` statements in python, R, and other languages
 - When a condition is introduced, we check whether it evaluates to TRUE
 - If it is true, we proceed with a desired command, calculation, value, etc
 - If it is not true, we move to the next condition
 - If it is true, we proceed with another desired command, calculation, value, etc
 - ...all the way until we run out of conditions
 - For all FALSE conditions, we can use an `ELSE` statement if we want to

CASE Command

- The results of a CASE statement will be a new column
- Best practice is to name the new column using AS new_column_name

```
CASE
  WHEN [something is true]
    THEN [value or calculation]
  WHEN [something else is true]
    THEN [value or calculation]
  ELSE [value or calculation]
END
```


CASE Command

(CASE live coding)

DISTINCT Command

- Not all queries will result in unique rows (i.e. duplicates are present)
 - **Can we think of why this is? Write your thoughts in the etherpad!**

DISTINCT Command

- `DISTINCT` has two possible spots within a query:
 - One comes immediately after `SELECT`, before column names are specified
 - e.g. `SELECT DISTINCT songs, albums, artists...`
 - This `DISTINCT` will govern the entire query
 - The other comes within aggregation (we'll get to this later)
 - e.g. `COUNT(DISTINCT products)`
 - This `DISTINCT` will only affect this specific aggregation

DISTINCT Command

(`DISTINCT` live coding)

Building Queries:

Fundamental Three Commands

Two More Commands

→ Putting Things Together with JOIN

Joining Tables

- Joins are used to combine data stored in different tables into a single table

Joining Tables

- Joins are the "Cartesian product" of two tables with *conditional selection(s)* of specific rows

- A Cartesian product combines all possible row values with another

- An easy example is a deck of cards:

combining four suits:

{♠, ♥, ♦, ♣}

with thirteen ranks:

{A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2}

produces 52 cards ($4 * 13$)

- To create a Cartesian Product in SQL we use `CROSS JOIN` (rare, but not unheard of)

Joining Tables

- Joins require relationships (with one exception, `CROSS JOIN`) between tables
- Different joins create different results
 - Join names specify which conditional selection is desired

Joining Tables

- There are three join types in SQL but different joining criteria can further limit results
- The most permitting join is a `FULL OUTER JOIN` and the least permitting is an `INNER JOIN`
 - Let's explore what this means by looking at each of them

JOIN Syntax

Syntax for a join is as follows:

```
SELECT [columns]  
FROM [left table]  
JOIN [right table]  
ON [left table.matching column] = [right table.matching column]
```

Joining Tables

A couple of notes:

- You will need to specify which join type is desired:
 - e.g. `INNER JOIN`
- Matching columns do not need to have the same name, just the same value
 - e.g. `ON table1.LetterGrade = table2.Alphabet` will work because A=A, B=B, C=C, etc
- You can specify more than one column to be joined
 - e.g. `ON table1.FirstName = table2.FirstName AND table1.LastName = table2.LastName`

INNER JOIN

- **INNER JOIN** filters both tables to rows present in both tables
- **INNER JOIN** does not produce **NULL** values
- **INNER JOIN** is the "default" join
 - i.e. queries do not need to specify "INNER", though it's good practice to write INNER

Source: Image: Teate, Chapter 5
(+annotations by me)

Inner Join

Only rows from the "right table" and "left table" where values in the specified fields have matches in both tables

Colour	Quantity		Colour	Quantity
Pink	1		Pink	1
Blue	1		Teal	3
Green	2		Green	2
Yellow	2		Gold	2
Black	6		Black	6
Orange	3		Orange	3
Red	1		Crimson	2
Purple	1		Purple	2

Inner Join Result Set

	Colour	Quantity	Colour	Quantity
1	Pink	1	Pink	1
2	Green	2	Green	2
3	Black	6	Black	6
4	Orange	3	Orange	3

INNER JOIN

A quick note on table aliasing:

- It is very common practice to alias table names
 - It makes join criteria much more concise
 - It simplifies `SELECT` statements when column names are the same
 - This is a common error: *"ambiguous column name"*
 - SQL requires you to specify *which* table you are returning the result from
- Generally, tables are aliased with the first letter (or first few letters) of the table so they can be easily referenced
 - `product AS p`
 - `product_category AS pc`

INNER JOIN

(INNER JOIN live coding)

LEFT (OUTER) JOIN

- **LEFT JOIN** filters the "right" table to rows present in the "left" table
- **LEFT JOIN** will most often produce **NULL** values
- The "OUTER" in **LEFT OUTER JOIN** is optional
 - Generally, OUTER seems to be excluded, but both are correct
- **LEFT** is *not* optional; there is no "OUTER JOIN"

Source: Image: Teate, Chapter 5 (+annotations by me)

Left Join

All rows from the "left table", and only rows from the "right table" with matching values in the specified fields

Colour	Quantity		Colour	Quantity
Pink	1	---	Pink	1
Blue	1		Teal	3
Green	2	---	Green	2
Yellow	2		Gold	2
Black	6	---	Black	6
Orange	3	---	Orange	3
Red	1		Crimson	2
Purple	1		Purple	2

Left Join Result Set

	Colour	Quantity	Colour	Quantity
1	Pink	1	Pink	1
2	Blue	1	NULL	NULL
3	Green	2	Green	2
4	Yellow	2	NULL	NULL
5	Black	6	Black	6
6	Orange	3	Orange	3
7	Red	1	NULL	NULL
8	Purple	1	NULL	NULL

LEFT (OUTER) JOIN

(LEFT JOIN live coding)

RIGHT (OUTER) JOIN

- **RIGHT JOIN** filters the "left" table to rows present in the "right" table
- **RIGHT JOIN** will most often produce **NULL** values
- The "OUTER" in **RIGHT OUTER JOIN** is optional
 - Generally, OUTER seems to be excluded, but both are correct

Source: Image: Teate, Chapter 5 (+annotations by me)

Right Join

All rows from the "right table", and only rows from the "left table" with matching values in the specified fields

Colour	Quantity		Colour	Quantity
Pink	1	---	Pink	1
Blue	1		Teal	3
Green	2	---	Green	2
Yellow	2		Gold	2
Black	6	---	Black	6
Orange	3	---	Orange	3
Red	1		Crimson	2
Purple	1		Purple	2

Right Join Result Set

	Colour	Quantity	Colour	Quantity
1	Pink	1	Pink	1
2	Green	2	Green	2
3	Black	6	Black	6
4	Orange	3	Orange	3
5	NULL	NULL	Teal	3
6	NULL	NULL	Gold	2
7	NULL	NULL	Crimson	2
8	NULL	NULL	Purple	2

RIGHT (OUTER) JOIN

- `RIGHT JOIN` is somewhat frowned upon, but sometimes they make sense
 - Often your query can be reorganized to use a `LEFT JOIN` instead

Source: Image: Teate, Chapter 5

Right Join

All rows from the "right table", and only rows from the "left table" with matching values in the specified fields

Colour	Quantity		Colour	Quantity
Pink	1	---	Pink	1
Blue	1		Teal	3
Green	2	---	Green	2
Yellow	2		Gold	2
Black	6	---	Black	6
Orange	3	---	Orange	3
Red	1		Crimson	2
Purple	1		Purple	2

FULL (OUTER) JOIN

- FULL OUTER JOIN does not filter either "left" or "right" table
- Expect NULL values to be produced from a FULL OUTER JOIN
- My experience has been to write FULL OUTER JOIN rather than FULL JOIN but this is personal preference

Full Outer Join Result Set

	Colour	Quantity	Colour	Quantity
1	Pink	1	Pink	1
2	Blue	1	NULL	NULL
3	Green	2	Green	2
4	Yellow	2	NULL	NULL
5	Black	6	Black	6
6	Orange	3	Orange	3
7	Red	1	NULL	NULL
8	Purple	1	NULL	NULL
9	NULL	NULL	Teal	3
10	NULL	NULL	Gold	2
11	NULL	NULL	Crimson	2
12	NULL	NULL	Purple	2

Filtering a FULL (OUTER) JOIN

- All OUTER JOIN syntax can be filtered to exclude the *matching* criteria
 - Often called an ANTI JOIN, i.e. what's *not* in the other table

```
SELECT *  
FROM table_1  
{LEFT | RIGHT | FULL} OUTER JOIN table_2  
ON table_1.key = table_2.key  
WHERE {table_1.key IS NULL | table_2.key IS NULL |  
      table_1.key IS NULL OR table_2.key IS NULL}
```

Anti Join Result Set

	Colour	Quantity	Colour	Quantity
1	Blue	1	NULL	NULL
2	Yellow	2	NULL	NULL
3	Red	1	NULL	NULL
4	Purple	1	NULL	NULL
5	NULL	NULL	Teal	3
6	NULL	NULL	Gold	2
7	NULL	NULL	Crimson	2
8	NULL	NULL	Purple	2

Multiple Table Joins

- More than one table can be joined at a time

```
SELECT *  
FROM table_1  
{INNER | LEFT | FULL JOIN} table_2  
  ON table_1.key = table_2.key  
{INNER | LEFT | FULL JOIN} table_3  
  ON {table_1 | table_2}.key = table_3.key  
{INNER | LEFT | FULL JOIN} table_n  
  ON {table_1 | table_2 | table_3}.key = table_n.key
```

Multiple Table Joins

- The order and type of joins will have significant effect on the final result set
- It's important to determine which table should be the `FROM` table
- Sometimes you have to experiment a bit to get things right
- **Can you imagine scenarios based on your knowledge of different `JOIN` types that result in significantly different outputs?**

Multiple Table Joins

(Multiple Table Joins live coding)

What questions do you have about anything from today?